Statistical-information readiness: the USAFacts ladder and where agencies stand

Prepared for the Interagency Council on Statistical Policy. Generated by `scripts/dn020_documents_build.py` from the framework record and the cycle of record.

USAFacts, a heavy consumer of federal data, has set out a framework for making government data ready for the programs the public now uses to reach it: three tracks, Agentic Access, Agentic Context and Agentic Evaluation, each a short ladder an agency climbs at its own pace, with three prerequisites that hold before any rung counts. It is worth adopting because it names a destination in plain terms and lets each agency place itself and decide where to invest next, rather than asking for everything at once.

Figure One goes here. Add reports/figures/dn020/1.png to place the illustration.

Figure one. Three tracks, three levels in each, and three prerequisites that hold before any level applies.

Where the agencies stand today. The readiness diagnostic has placed sixteen federal statistical agencies on the ladder from the outside, measuring the prerequisites and the lower rungs that a public request can reach.

Figure Three goes here. Add reports/figures/dn020/3.png to place the illustration.

Figure three. Of sixteen agencies, eleven pass every measured check at Access I and one at Access II; on the Context track two pass at Context I and one at Context II. No agency is measured above these rungs, and the Evaluation track carries no check yet.

What an agency gets from the diagnostic. For each track it receives its own rung and the single next thing that would raise it one rung, read from published criteria rather than asserted. A check that could not be measured for an agency names its reason and never counts against it, so an agency sees where it stands and what to do next, not a grade.

The Evaluation track, where an agency would publish evaluation sets and benchmark results, carries no check yet: measuring it is a testing-and-evaluation programme, not a reading a public request can take, and it is shown empty rather than scored.

SI use: in these pages SI means statistical information, the data a federal statistical agency publishes for the public; the readiness described is whether a program acting for a member of the public can reach that statistical information and the documentation that travels with it. The letters AI appear only inside USAFacts' own titles and the framework captions quoted here.